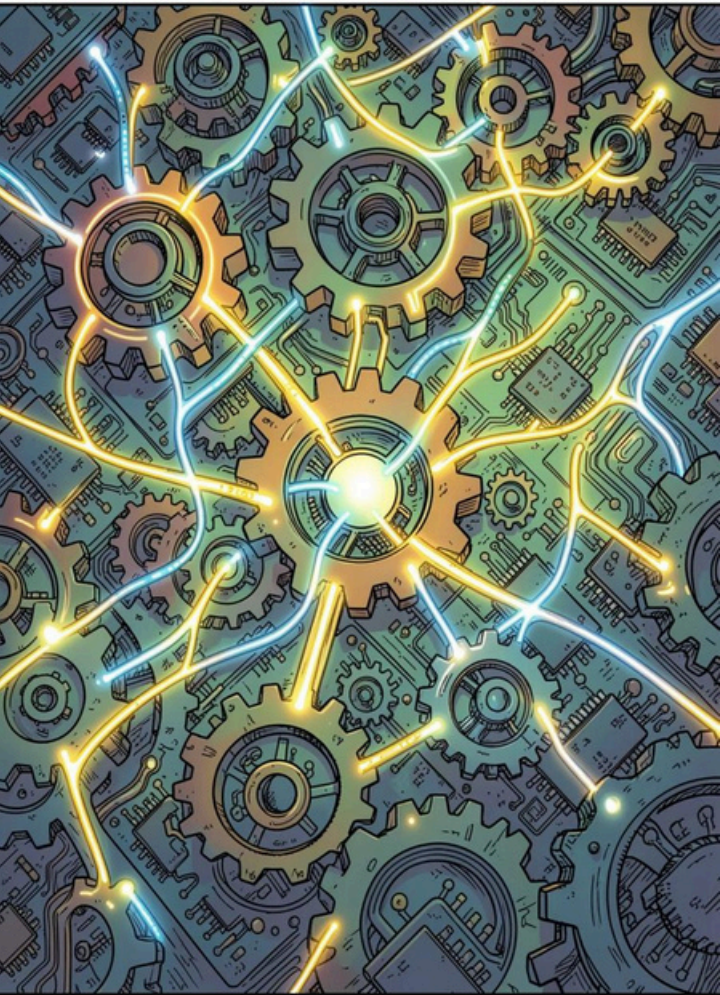




The Engine of Modern Business

Foundation

Systems as the backbone of operational success

Evolution

From record-keeping to strategic decision support

Sociotechnical

Optimising both technology and human teams

The Five Core Components



People

Specialists & end-users driving value



Hardware & Software

*Physical and programmed
infrastructure*



Data Resources

*Raw facts converted into business
intelligence*



Networks

*Connective tissue linking global
operations*



Policies & Procedures

*Frameworks ensuring ethical, secure
use*

ERA I

1950s–1970s: The Data Processing Era



1950s

*Automated
accounting &
transaction
processing*

1960s
*Management
reporting
systems
introduced*

1970s
Decision

*support
systems —
what-if
analysis*

ERA 2

1980s–1990s: Strategic Integration

End-User Computing

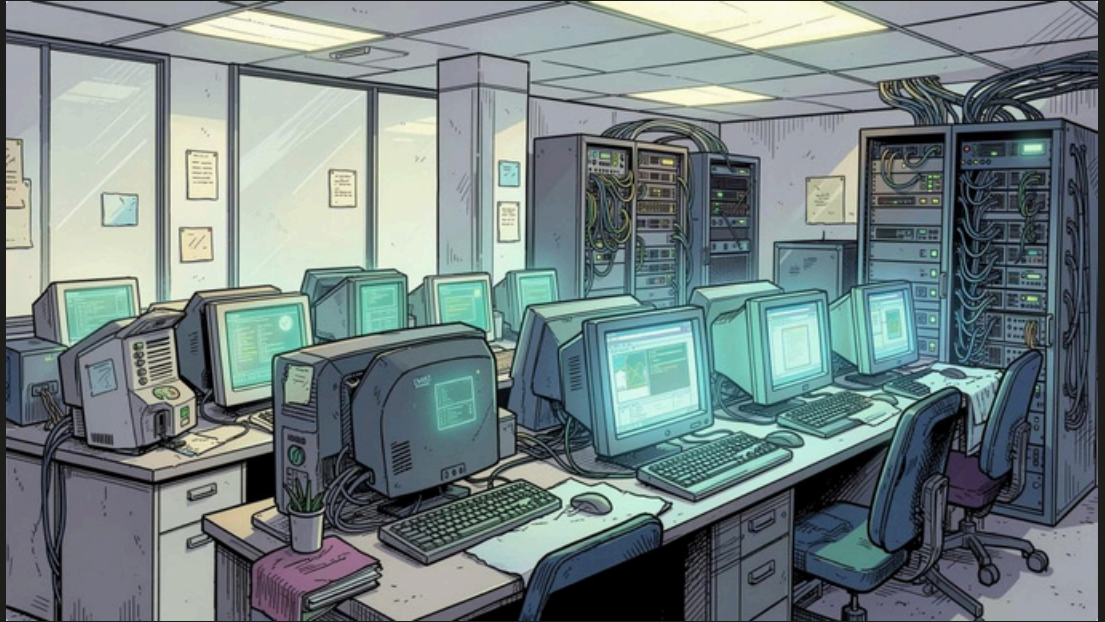
Powershifts to the functional level

Executive Information Systems

High-level, graphical data for leadership

Enterprise Computing

Siloed departments finally linked together



Operations Support Systems

Transaction Processing

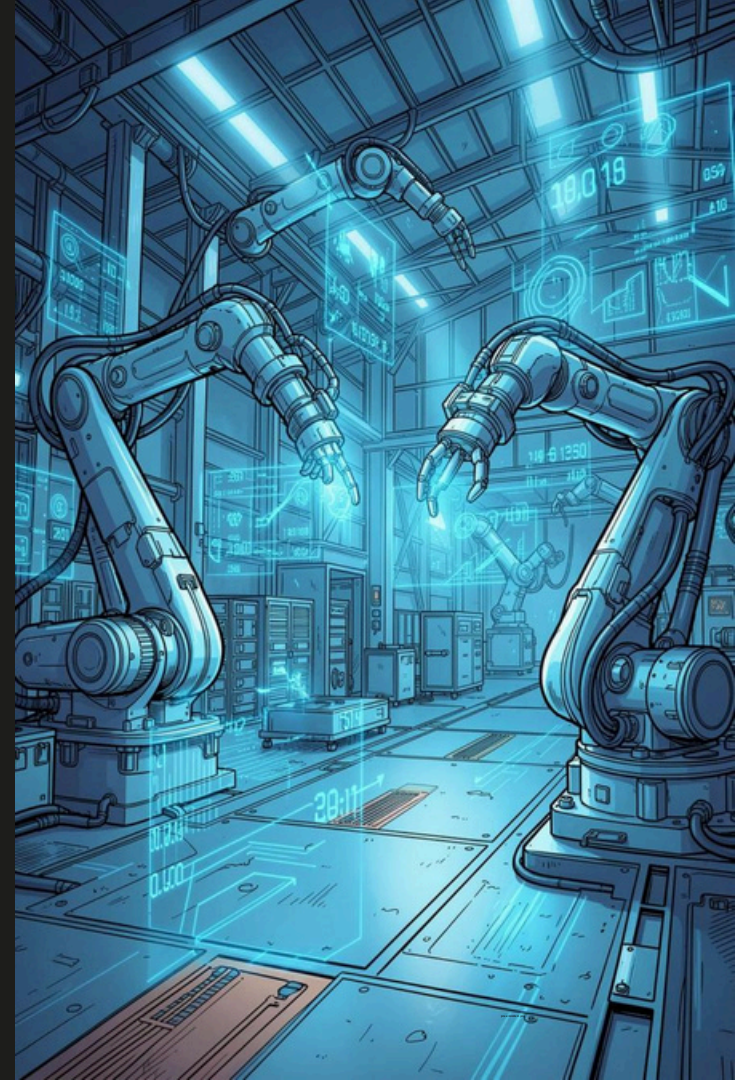
Real-time inventory & sales tracking

Process Control

Sensors & automated manufacturing feedback

Enterprise Collaboration

Virtual teams & groupware reducing coordination costs



TRANSFORMATION

The Digital Economy

→ Physical → Digital

Products and platforms go global

→ E-Business Revolution

Digitally-enabled supplier & customer relationships

→ Flatter Organisations

Location-independent work reshapes hierarchies



The Strategic Six: Why Businesses Invest



Operational Excellence



New Business Models



Customer & Supplier Intimacy



Better Decision Making



Competitive Advantage



Survival



Modern Challenges: The Post-Digital Landscape



Big Data & Cloud

*Utility-based, high-powered
infrastructure at scale*



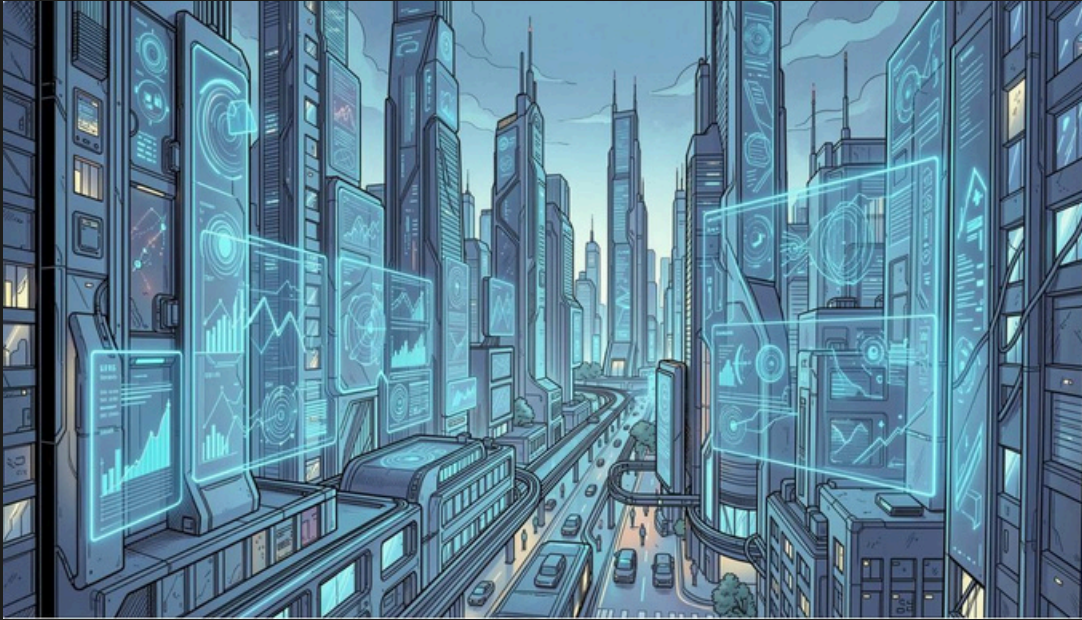
Globalisation

*Coordinating global systems
ethically across borders*



Security & Ethics

Protecting assets while ensuring social responsibility



THE FUTURE

The Fully Digital Firm

Rapid Sensing

*Responding to environmental changes
in real time*

Digital-First Processes

*Core operations mediated entirely
through digital networks*

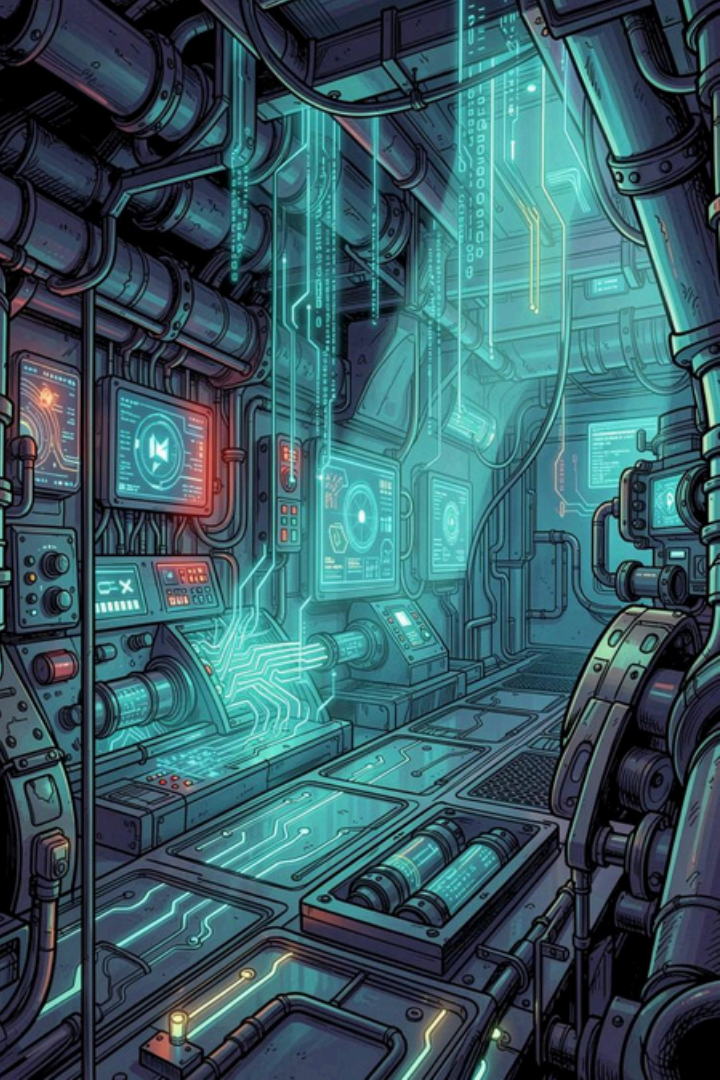
The Winning Formula

*Competitive advantage depends on how
well social and technical systems
adapt together*



IT and Business Systems

Transforming the Modern Enterprise



The Engine of Modern Business

Foundation

Systems as the backbone of operational success

Evolution

From record-keeping to strategic decision support

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Optimising technology and human teams together

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People

Specialists and end-users



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*Physical and programmed
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*Facts converted to business
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Networks

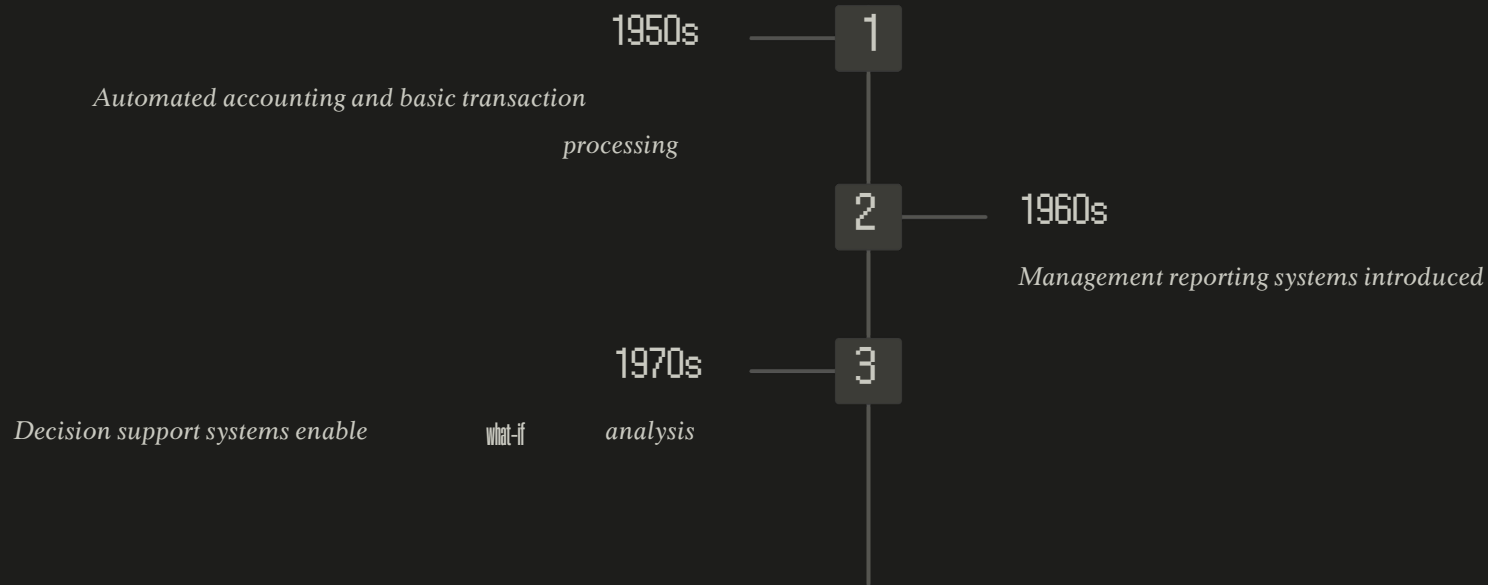
Connective tissue for global operations



Policies & Procedures

Frameworks for ethical, secure use

The 1950s–1970s: The Data Processing Era



The 1980s–1990s: Strategic Integration

End-User Computing

Power shifts to the functional level

Executive Information Systems

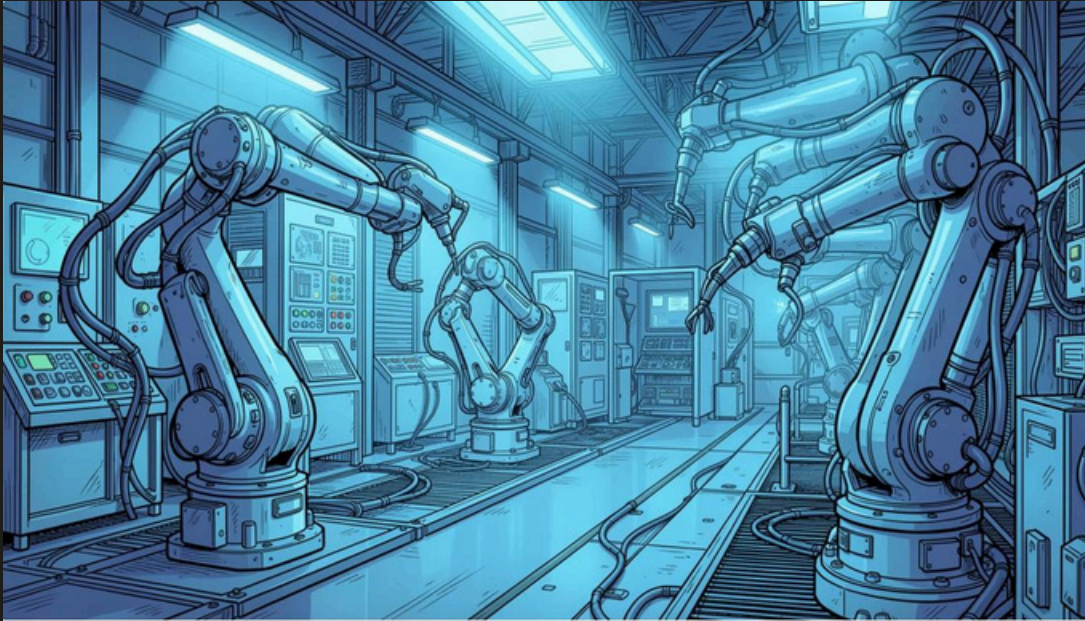
High-level, graphical data for leadership

Enterprise Computing

Previously siloed departments finally linked



Operations Support Systems



Transaction Processing

Real-time inventory and sales tracking



Process Control

Sensors and automated manufacturing feedback



Enterprise Collaboration

Virtual teams and groupware reducing coordination costs

The Digital Economy Transformation

1

Physical → Digital

Products and platforms go global

2

E-Business Revolution

Digitally-enabled supplier and customer relationships

3

Flattened Hierarchies

Location-independent work reshapes organisations



The Strategic Six: Why Businesses Invest



Operational Excellence

Higher productivity



New Business Models

E-commerce and subscriptions



Customer & Supplier Intimacy

Personalised experiences



Better Decision Making

Real-time digital dashboards



Competitive Advantage

Sustainable market leadership



Survival

Technology for compliance and operation

Modern Challenges: The Post-Digital Landscape



The post-digital era demands more than technology adoption —it requires ethical governance, global coordination, and resilient infrastructure.

The Future: The Fully Digital Firm

Rapid Sensing

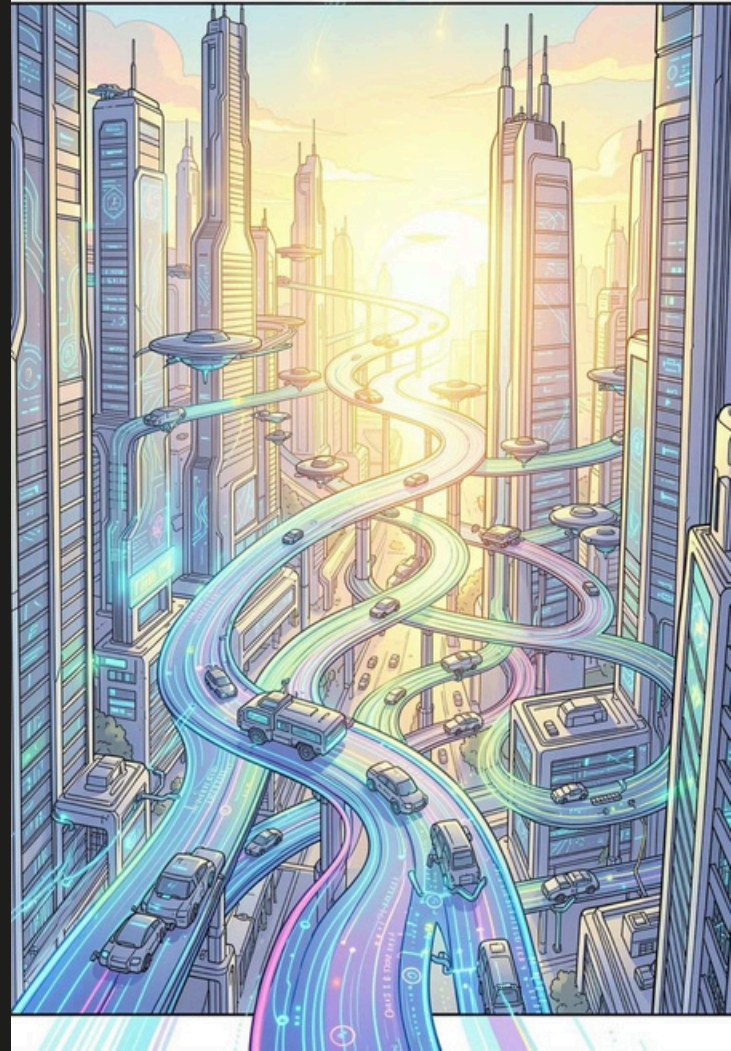
Instant response to environmental changes

Digital-First Processes

Core operations mediated entirely through digital networks

Sociotechnical Adaptation

Competitive advantage depends on how effectively social and technical systems evolve together





Introduction to the Business Analyst Role

*A comprehensive guide for aspiring and entry-level business analysts
—covering responsibilities, core skills, methodologies, and stakeholder
management.*

What You Will Learn

Course Overview

01

Definition & Responsibilities

Understand what a Business Analyst does and why the role matters.

02

Key Skills

Explore the core competencies every BA must develop.

03

Methodologies

Learn Agile, Waterfall, and how to choose the right approach.

04

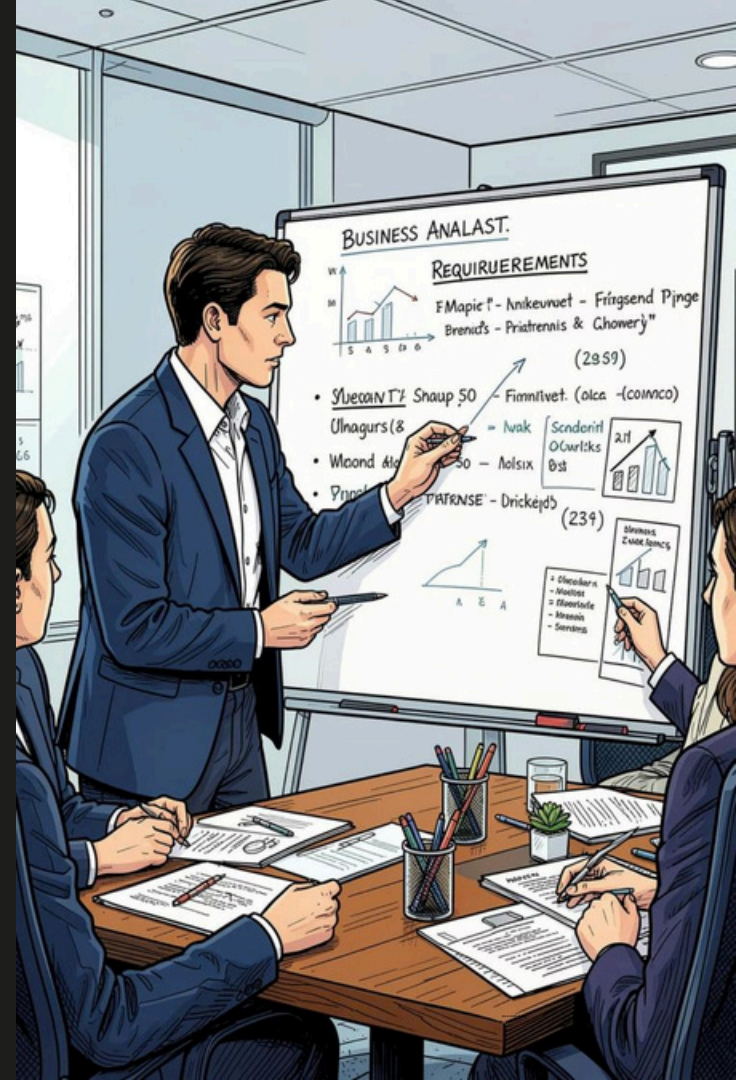
Stakeholder Management

Master the art of engaging and aligning diverse stakeholders.

Section A

What Is a Business Analyst?

A Business Analyst (BA) acts as a bridge between business stakeholders and technical teams. BAs identify business needs, analyze processes, and recommend solutions that deliver measurable value. They translate complex problems into clear, actionable requirements —making them essential to every successful project.



Section A –Responsibilities

Core Responsibilities of a BA



Requirements Gathering

Elicit, document, and validate business and functional requirements from stakeholders.



Process Analysis

Map current-state processes and design improved future-state workflows.



Solution Evaluation

Assess proposed solutions to ensure they meet business objectives and constraints.



Stakeholder Communication

Facilitate clear communication between business units and technical teams.

Section B

Key Skills for Business Analysts



Communication

Articulate ideas clearly in writing and verbally across all levels of an organization.

Analytical Thinking

Break down complex problems, identify patterns, and draw evidence-based conclusions.

Problem-Solving

Propose practical, innovative solutions that balance business needs with technical feasibility.

Section B –Skills in Practice

How These Skills Come Together



Active Listening

Understand stakeholder needs before proposing any solution.



Data Interpretation

Read charts, reports, and metrics to support decision-making.



Creative Thinking

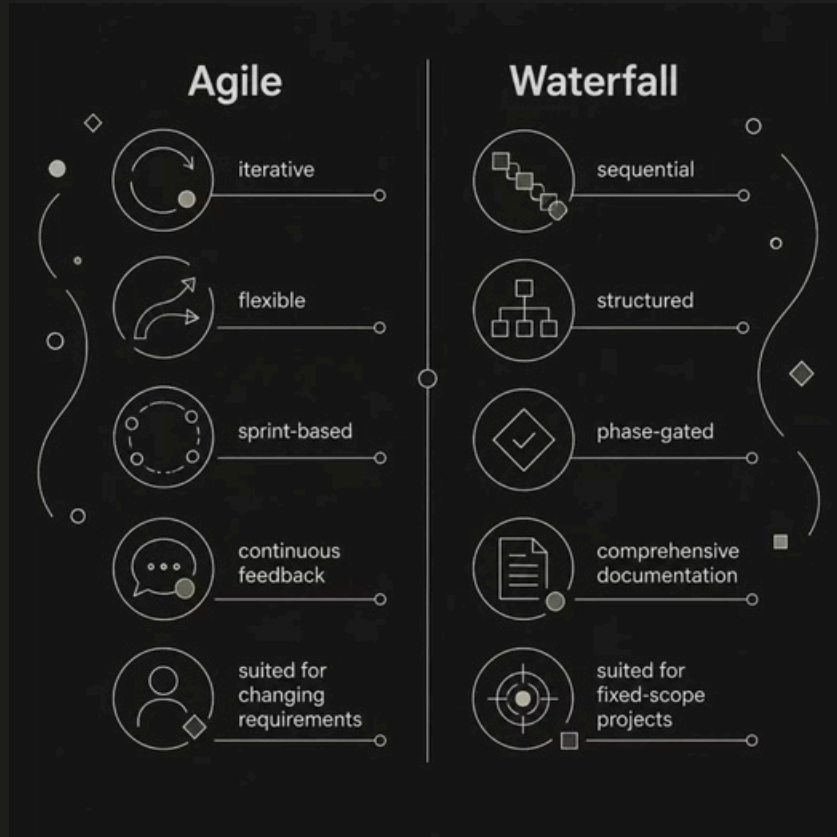
Challenge assumptions and explore alternative approaches.



Negotiation

Balance competing priorities to reach consensus.

Business Analysis Methodologies



The right methodology depends on your project's nature. Agile thrives in dynamic environments where requirements evolve. Waterfall excels when scope is well-defined and changes are costly. Many modern teams adopt a *hybrid approach*, blending structure with flexibility.

Understanding both methodologies makes you a more adaptable and valuable BA.

Section C -Deep Dive

Agile vs. Waterfall: When to Use Which

Choose Agile When...

- Requirements are expected to change
- Fast delivery of working solutions is needed
- Stakeholders can engage frequently

Choose Waterfall When...

- Scope is fixed and well-understood
- Regulatory documentation is required
- Changes are expensive or risky



Section D

Stakeholder Management

Who Are Stakeholders?

Stakeholders are anyone affected by or influencing a project — clients, end-users, sponsors, developers, and regulators.

Effective BA work depends on understanding each stakeholder's needs, expectations, and level of influence.

Key Practices

- Identify and map stakeholders early
- Tailor communication to each audience
- Manage expectations proactively
- Build trust through transparency



Key Takeaways

Your BA Journey Starts Here

4

Core Topics Covered

*Definition, Skills, Methodologies,
Stakeholders*

3

Essential Skills

*Communication, Analytical Thinking,
Problem-Solving*

2

Key Methodologies

*Agile and Waterfall—know when to
apply each*



A great Business Analyst combines technical knowledge with strong people skills —always curious, always communicating, always adding value.



Data vs. Information

Understanding the difference between raw data and meaningful information is the foundation of every decision we make—in business, science, and everyday life.

FUNDAMENTALS OF DATA & INFORMATION

What Is Raw Data?

Data is the *raw material* of the digital world —unprocessed, unorganised facts and figures with no meaning on their own. A list of numbers, a set of symbols, or a collection of observations are all examples of data.

Unstructured

No inherent order or context

Objective

Facts without interpretation

Examples

37, "Mumbai", 14:30, Red





KEY CONCEPT

What Is Information?

data that has been
Information is
processed, organised, or
structured to give it meaning and
purpose. When data is placed in
context, it becomes information —
something that answers questions and
supports understanding.

Contextualised

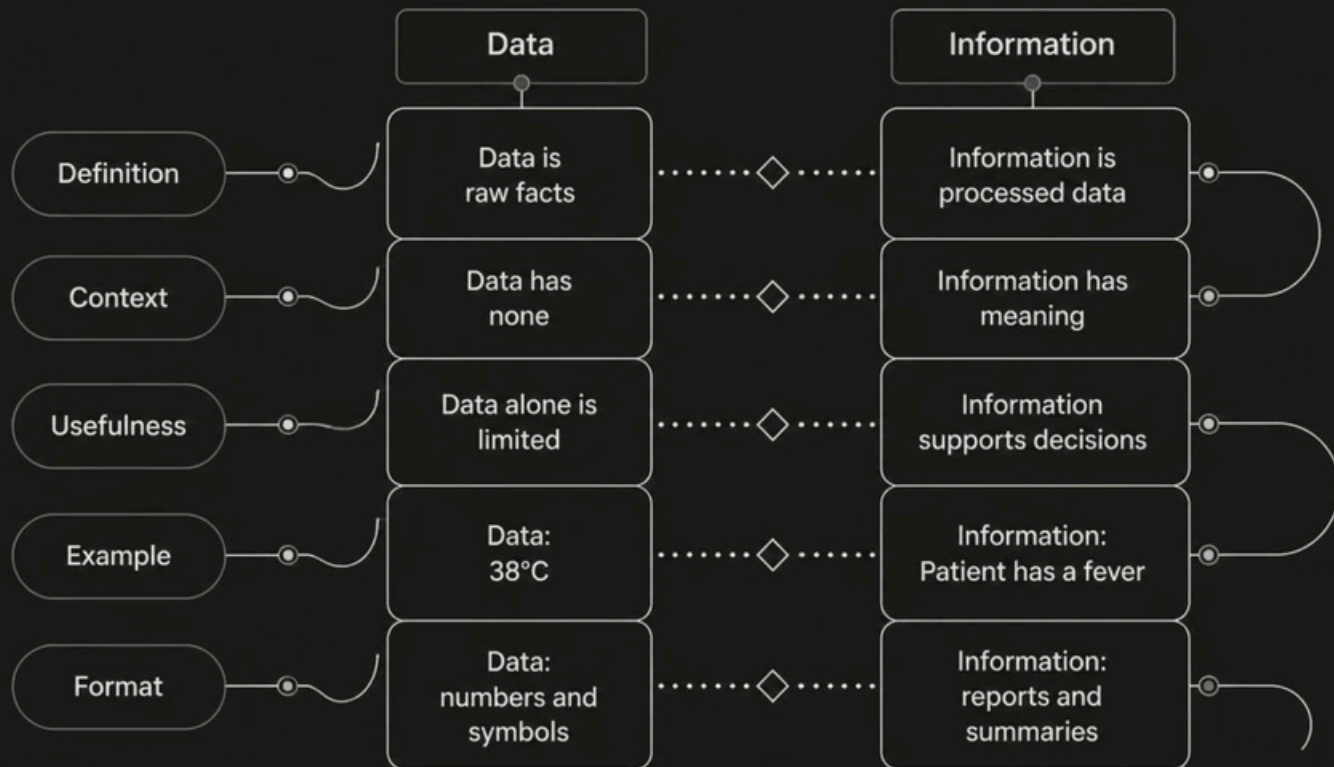
Connected to a situation or purpose

Actionable

Can be used to make decisions

Data vs. Information: Side by Side

Understanding the distinction helps us communicate more precisely and think more clearly about the value of what we collect and share.



The Transformation Process

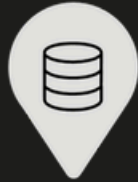
Data does not become valuable on its own. It must go through a deliberate process of

collection, processing, and interpretation

to become information—and ultimately, knowledge.

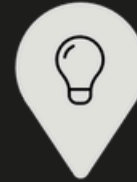
Data

*Raw, unorganised
facts*



Knowledge

*Applied
understanding for
decisions*



Information

*Processed,
contextualised data*



Each stage adds value—moving from meaningless inputs to insights that drive action.

From Data to Information: How It Happens

1

Collect

Gather raw facts from observations, sensors, or records

2

Process

Sort, filter, calculate, or organise the data

3

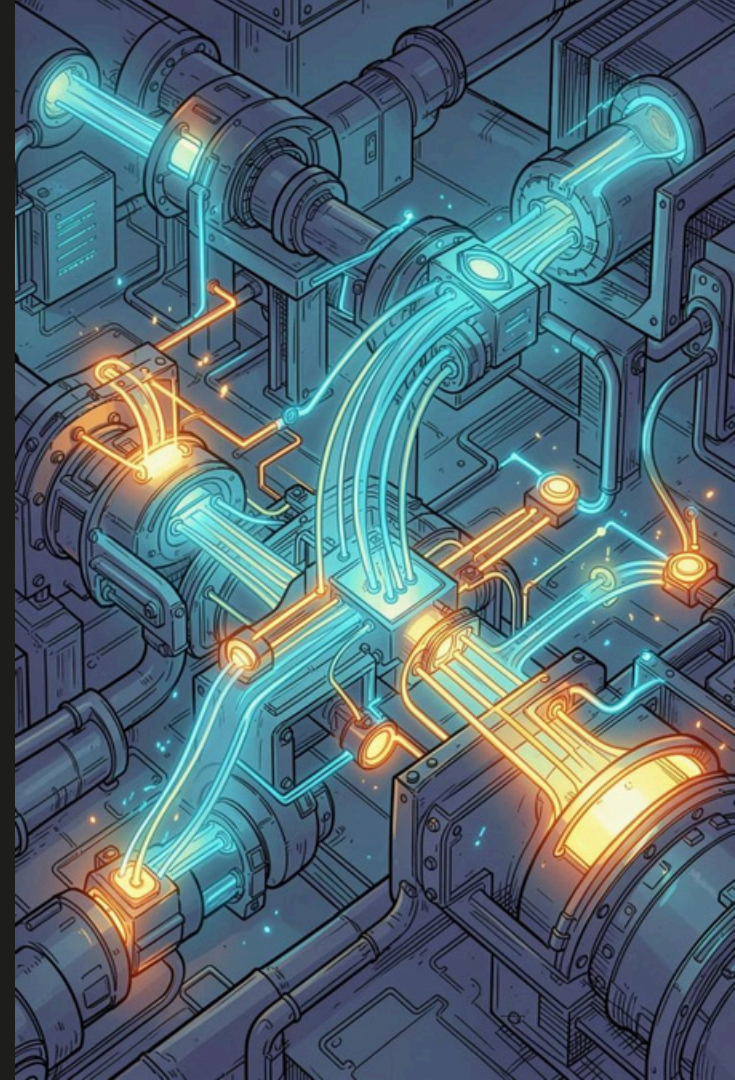
Contextualise

Relate the data to a specific situation or question

4

Communicate

Present it in a form that is understandable and useful



From Information to Knowledge

Information becomes Knowledge when...

A person understands, internalises, and applies

information based on experience, expertise, and judgement. Knowledge is what enables us to act wisely — not just know facts, but understand what they mean.



Knowledge is personal and contextual. Two people with the same information may draw different conclusions based on their experience.



Data

*38°C temperature
reading*



Information

Patient has a high fever



Knowledge

Doctor prescribes treatment

Why Information Drives Decisions

In any organisation, the quality of decisions depends directly on the quality of information available. Good information reduces uncertainty, highlights risks, and reveals opportunities.



Reduces Uncertainty

Replaces guesswork with evidence-based clarity



Enables Speed

Timely information allows faster, confident decisions



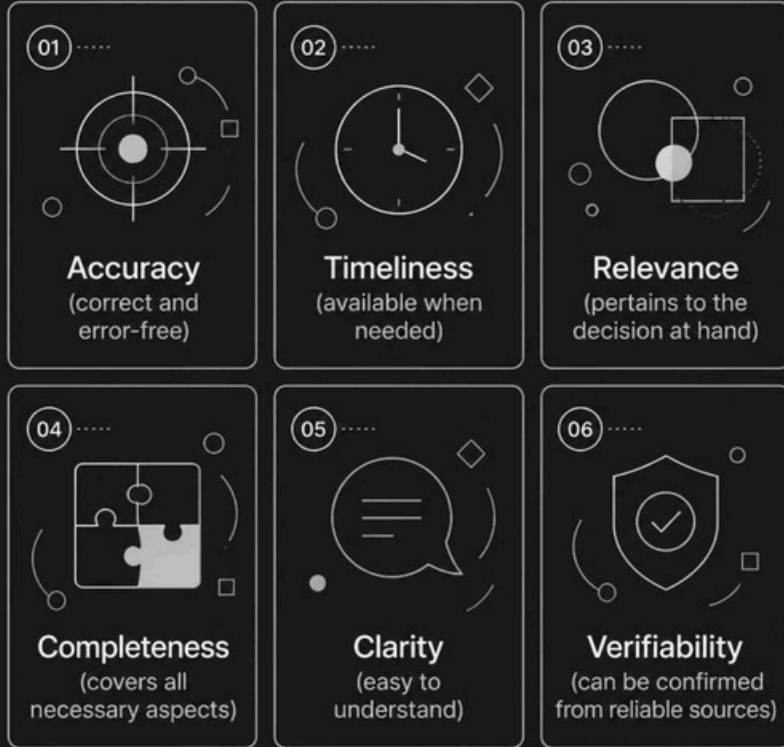
Minimises Risk

Accurate information helps avoid costly mistakes



What Makes Information Valuable?

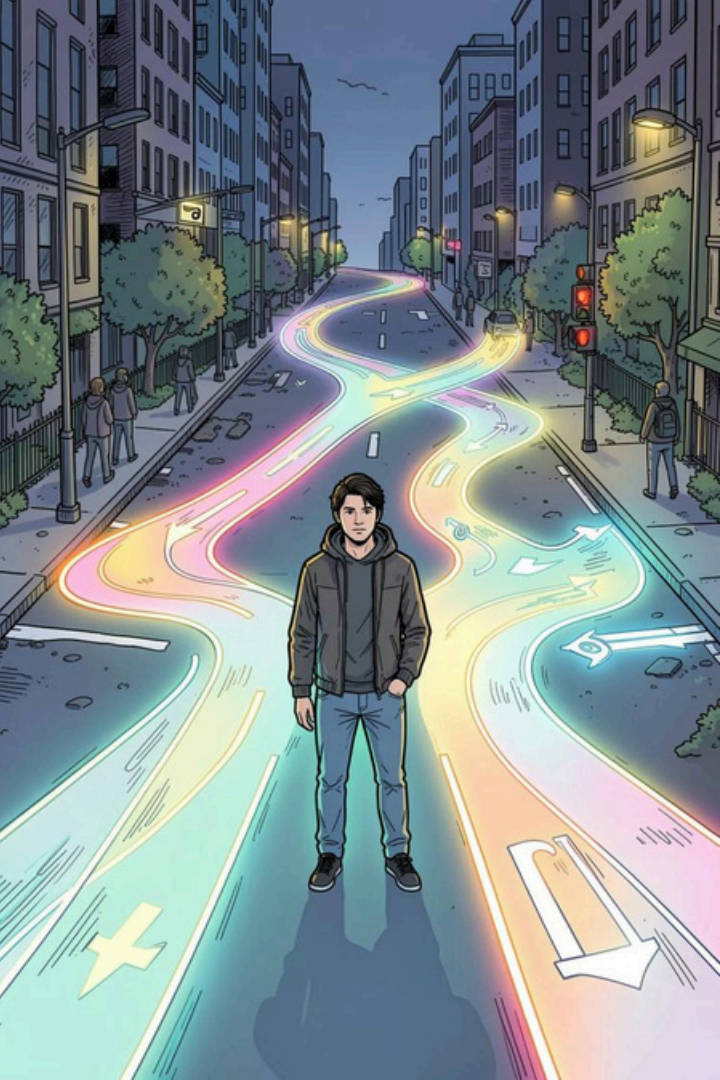
Not all information is equally useful. High-quality information has specific characteristics that make it truly valuable for decision-making.



The 6 Qualities

Information that is accurate, timely, relevant, complete, clear, and verifiable gives decision-makers the confidence to act.

Poor-quality information —outdated, incomplete, or inaccurate —can be worse than no information at all.



Key Takeaways

1 Data is raw; Information is meaningful

Data becomes information only after processing and contextualisation.

2 The transformation adds value at every stage

Data → Information → Knowledge is a progression from facts to understanding to action.

3 Quality information drives better decisions

Accurate, timely, and relevant information is the foundation of effective decision-making.



Data-Driven Decision Making

Transform raw data into strategic clarity. A practical framework for

managers and analysts who want to make smarter, evidence-based decisions.

What We Will Cover

This presentation walks through the four pillars of data-driven decision making—from core principles to real-world challenges.

01 Principles

The foundational mindset for using data effectively

02 Benefits

How data improves outcomes across the organisation

03

Process Steps

A structured approach from question to action

04

Challenges

Common pitfalls and how to avoid them

Core Principles of Data-Driven Decision Making



Effective data-driven decision making is grounded in four key principles that separate signal from noise.

Ask the Right Question

Define the problem clearly before collecting any data.

Trust Quality Over Quantity

Accurate, relevant data beats large volumes of noisy data.

Context Is King

Data without context leads to misinterpretation.

Act on Insights

Analysis without action has no business value.

B. BENEFITS

Why Data-Driven Decisions Win

Organisations that embed data into their decision processes consistently outperform those that rely on intuition alone.

Greater Accuracy

Reduces guesswork and cognitive bias, leading to more reliable outcomes.

Faster Execution

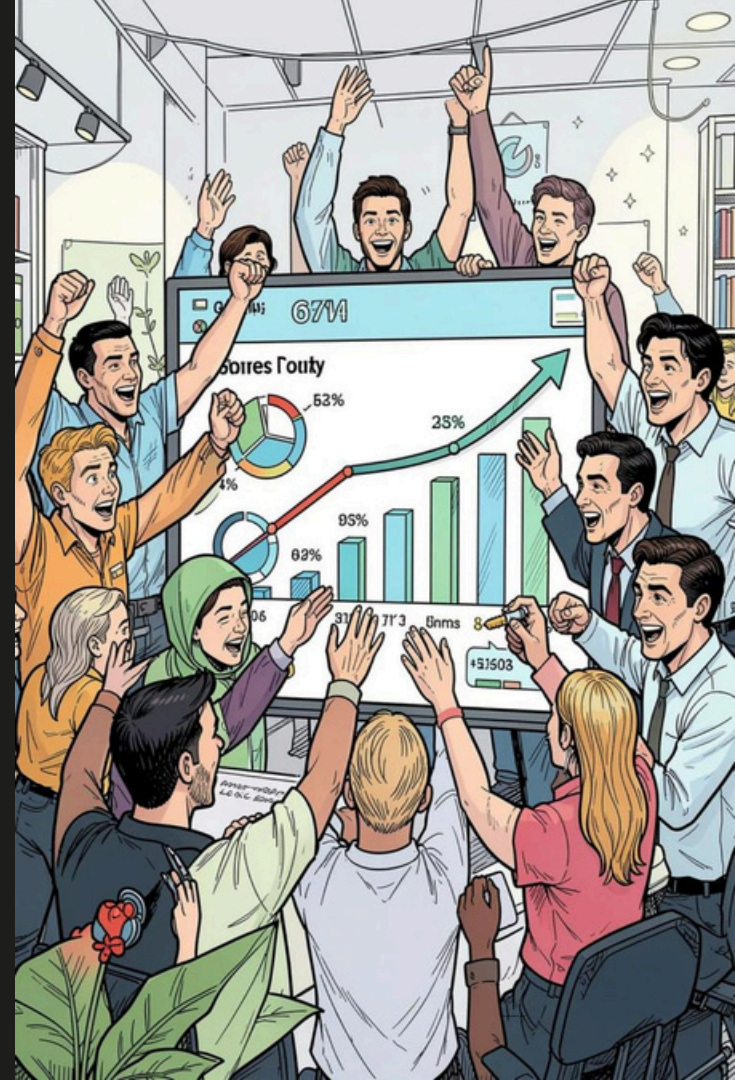
Clear data signals cut through debate and accelerate alignment.

Competitive Edge

Early identification of trends creates first-mover advantages.

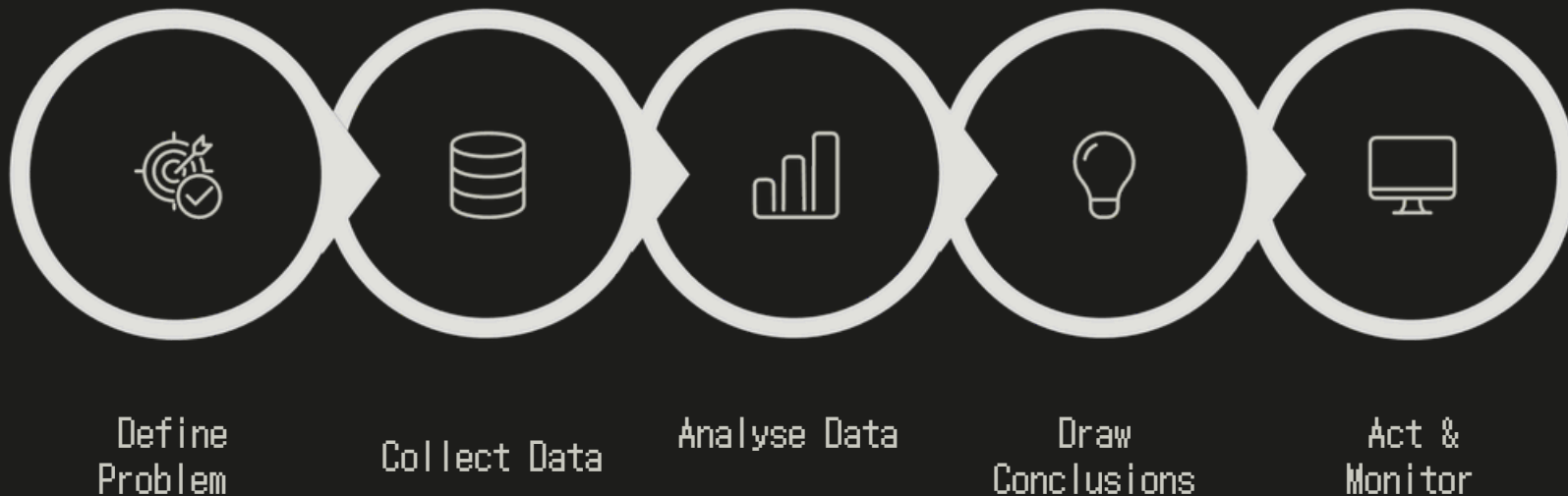
Accountability

Decisions backed by data are easier to justify and audit.



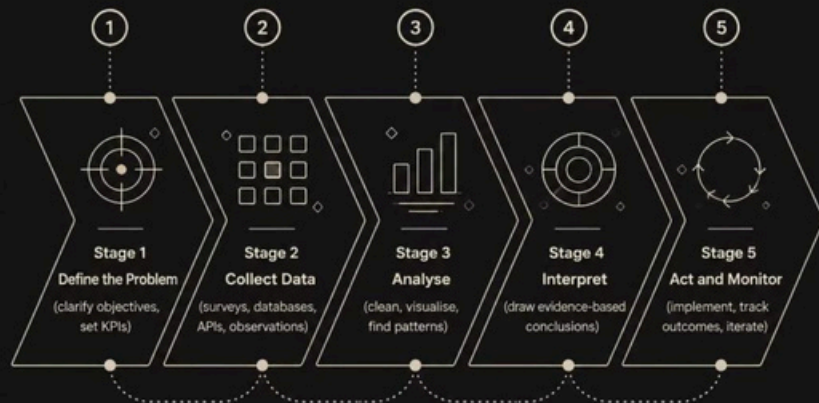
The Data-Driven Decision Process

Following a structured process ensures that data is used purposefully — not just available, but actionable.



Each step builds on the last. Skipping steps —especially problem definition —is the most common reason data initiatives fail to deliver value.

From Data Collection to Action



Key Considerations at Each Stage

- Define:** Align stakeholders on the exact question before proceeding.
- Collect:** Ensure data sources are reliable and representative.
- Analyse:** Use appropriate tools—from spreadsheets to BI platforms.
- Interpret:** Avoid confirmation bias; test alternative explanations.
- Act:** Set review checkpoints to measure if the decision worked.

Common Challenges & Pitfalls



Even well-intentioned data initiatives can go wrong. Awareness of these pitfalls is the first step to avoiding them.

Poor Data Quality

Incomplete, outdated, or inconsistent data leads to flawed conclusions.

Analysis Paralysis

Over-analysing delays decisions and erodes competitive momentum.

Confirmation Bias

Selecting data that supports pre-existing beliefs undermines objectivity.

More Pitfalls to Watch For



Data Silos

When departments hoard data, the organisation loses the full picture needed for strategic decisions.



Correlation vs Causation

Assuming that two correlated metrics imply causation is one of the most dangerous analytical errors.



Dashboard Overload

Too many metrics without prioritisation creates noise. Focus on the few KPIs that truly drive outcomes.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

Bringing It All Together

Start With the Question

Never collect data before you know what decision it will inform.

Follow the Process

Define → Collect → Analyse → Interpret → Act. Each step matters.

Guard Against Bias

Challenge assumptions and seek disconfirming evidence actively.

Iterate and Improve

Data-driven decision making is a discipline, not a one-time project.

❏ *The goal is not to eliminate intuition — it is to sharpen it with evidence.*



Your Next Steps

Begin embedding data-driven thinking into your team's culture today.

→ Audit Your Current Decisions

Identify 2–3 recurring decisions that could benefit from a data-backed approach.

→ Assess Your Data Readiness

Evaluate data quality, accessibility, and tooling gaps across your team.

→ Run a Pilot

Apply the five-step process to one real decision and measure the outcome.

Mastering Business Case Analysis

Turning Data into Decisions — a structured approach to solving real-world business challenges.

CASE STUDIES

BUSINESS STRATEGY



What is a Case Study?



A Living Story

A case study captures real people, complex problems, and unfolding events—not just numbers on a page.

Firsthand Experience

It offers a chance to "live" a business challenge, stepping into the shoes of the decision-maker.

Conflicting Perspectives

Beyond data, it involves navigating competing interests, diverse viewpoints, and ambiguous outcomes.



The Investigative Mindset

Before solving a case, you must learn to think like an investigator—not just an analyst.



Symptoms vs. Root Cause

Don't be fooled by surface-level problems. Dig deeper to find what's truly driving the issue.



Embrace Ambiguity

Not every case has a single perfect answer. Comfort with uncertainty is a professional strength.



Facts vs. Assumptions

Separate objective evidence from your own biases. Challenge what you think you know.

The First Read



Your first pass through a case sets the foundation. Don't get bogged down in details — build the big picture first.

Read the Introduction & Conclusion

These frame the entire narrative and reveal what's at stake.

Skim the Entire Case

Assess scope, tone, and structure before diving deep.

Identify the Key Actor

Who is the primary decision-maker? Their perspective drives the analysis.

STEP 2 OF 5

The Deep Dive

1

Re-Read with Purpose

Return to the case with specific questions. Every paragraph is now a clue.

2

Identify Key Issues

What is truly at stake? Prioritise problems by urgency and impact.

3

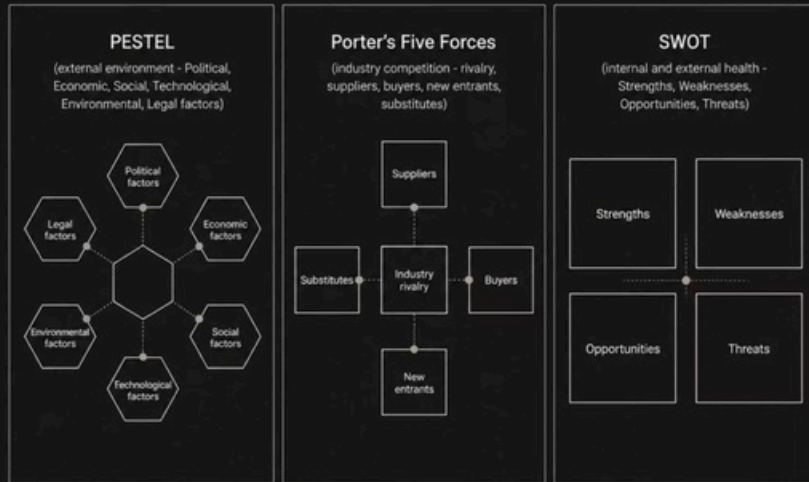
Decode the Financials

Treat numbers as evidence. Ratios, trends, and margins tell a hidden story.



Diagnostic Frameworks

Strategic tools bring order to chaos. Use them to structure your thinking and communicate clearly.



PESTEL

Scans the macro environment—ideal for understanding external pressures on a business.

Porter's Five Forces

Measures industry attractiveness and competitive intensity.

SWOT

Maps internal capabilities against external opportunities and threats.

Generating Alternatives



Before recommending a solution, explore the full landscape of possibilities. Rigour comes from comparison.

Brainstorm Freely

*Generate options without immediate judgment.
Quantity leads to quality.*

Evaluate Feasibility

Can the company afford it? Will stakeholders accept it? Is it executable?

Assess Risks & Resources

Every path has a cost. Identify what's required and what could go wrong.

STEP 5 OF 5

The Action Plan

Take a Firm Stand

Avoid sitting on the fence. A clear recommendation demonstrates conviction and analytical confidence.

Build a Timeline

Define short-term wins and long-term milestones. Show how the solution unfolds over time.

Define Success Metrics

How will you prove it works? Set measurable KPIs to validate your recommendation.



Classroom & Real-World Practice



Be Constructive

Suggest deeper ways to analyse data. Push beyond the obvious interpretation.



Stay Concise

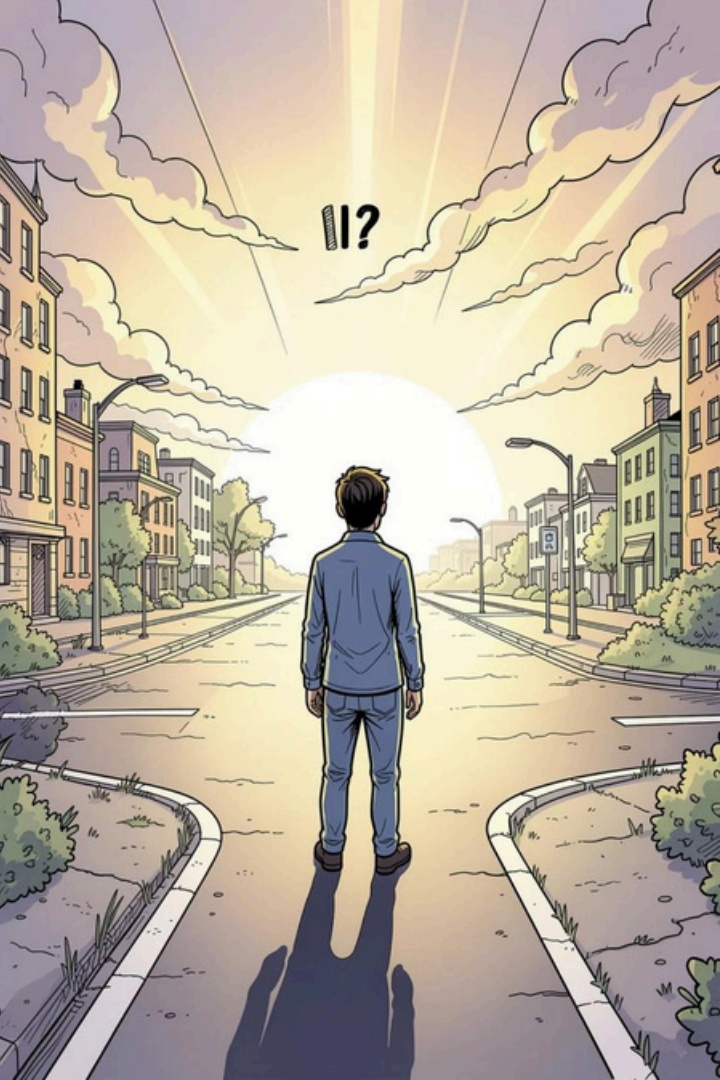
Keep contributions relevant and focused. Precision signals clarity of thought.



Think Like a Leader

Step into the role of a consultant or CEO. Own the decision, not just the analysis.





The Art of Asking Questions

Great decisions come from rigorous analysis, not intuition alone.

A Permanent Skill

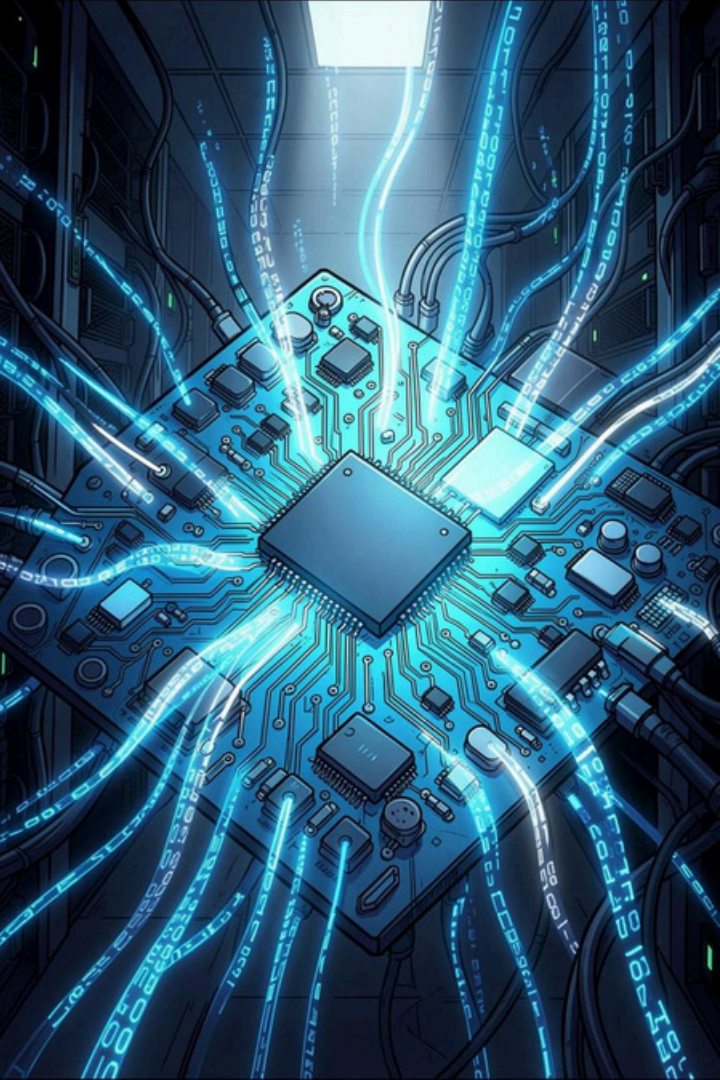
Cases change, industries evolve —but the ability to ask the right questions never loses value.

Master the Process

Your goal is to own the diagnostic framework, not just the answer to one case.

Create Sustainable Success

Use analysis to build solutions that are profitable, ethical, and enduring.



From Mainframes to
Markets

The IT Business Revolution

*How technology evolved from a back-office utility into the very engine
of modern commerce.*

1950S—1980S

The Early Era: Automating the Back Office

Internal Efficiency First

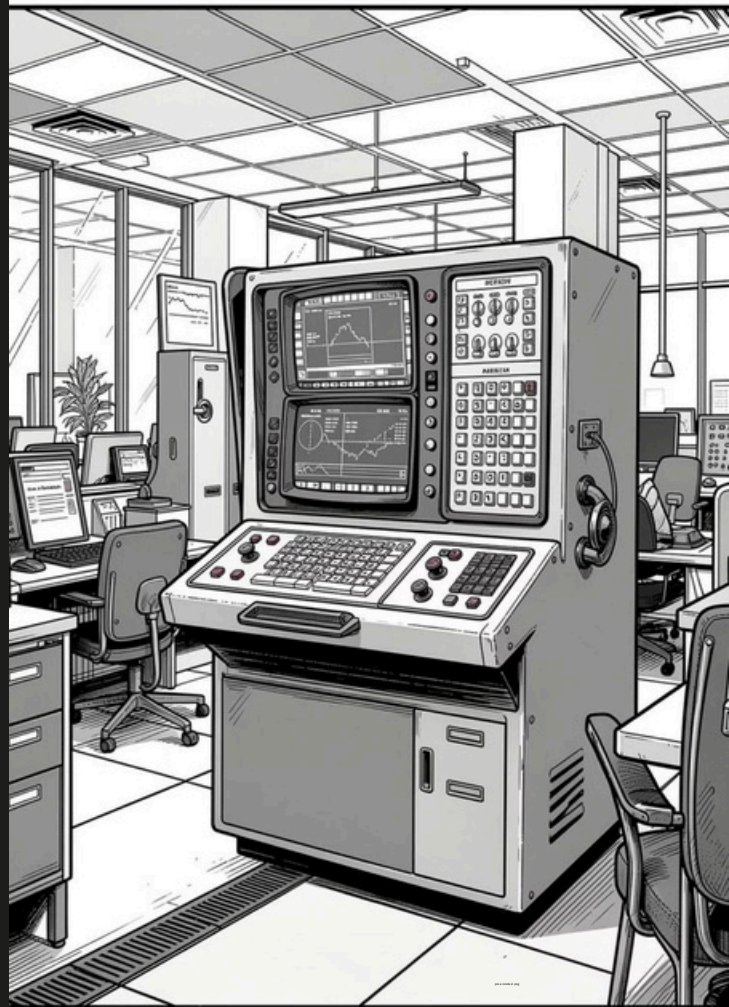
Mainframe computers were introduced to streamline accounting, payroll, and record-keeping — entirely invisible to customers.

IT as an Operational Cost

Early technology investment was expensive, risky, and seen purely as overhead — not a strategic asset.

Data Management, Not Strategy

The goal was simple: store and retrieve data faster. Competitive advantage was an afterthought.



LATE 1980S

The Strategic Pivot: IT as a Competitive Weapon



Moving Outward

Firms like Merrill Lynch leveraged technology to create cash management accounts — directly serving customers in ways competitors could not replicate.

A Paradigm Shift

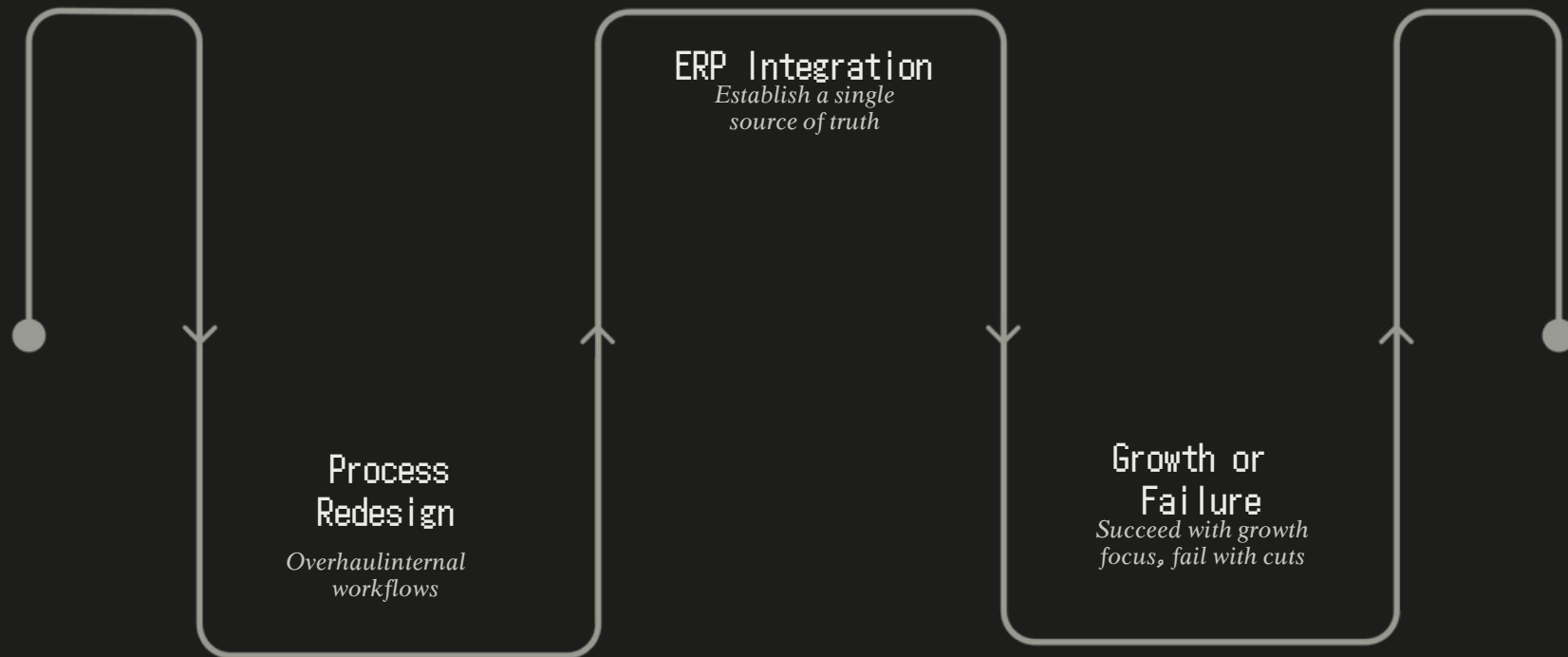
IT moved from a utility to a *proprietary* source of market advantage. For the first time, technology could differentiate a brand.



This era marked the birth of IT-driven customer differentiation.

1990s

Reengineering the Enterprise



The 1990s brought a radical ambition: not just automating existing processes, but reengineering was misused as a pretext for layoffs rather than a catalyst for growth.

re designing them entirely

. ERP systems promised enterprise-wide data unity—but many early projects failed when

1995–2000

The Dot-Com Frenzy: Peak Hype

The Internet Gold Rush

Billions poured into e-business models built on traffic, not profitability. "First-mover advantage" became the mantra.

The Bubble Bursts

Dot-coms collapsed en masse, teaching a hard lesson: tech hype is not a revenue model.

Orderly Application Emerges

Survivors shifted from frantic speculation to serious, disciplined business applications of the internet.



2003

"IT Doesn't Matter" –The Carr Controversy

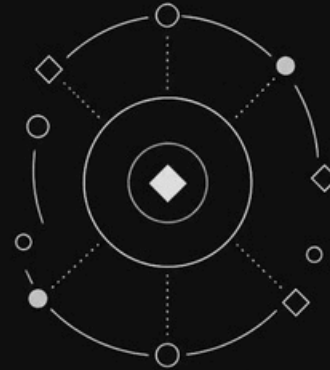
Nicholas Carr's Seminal Argument

In a landmark *Harvard Business Review* article, Carr argued that IT had become a *commodity*—like electricity or rail infrastructure. No longer a source of unique advantage, it was simply the cost of doing business.

The true competitive edge shifted back to the *business model*, not the technology stack.

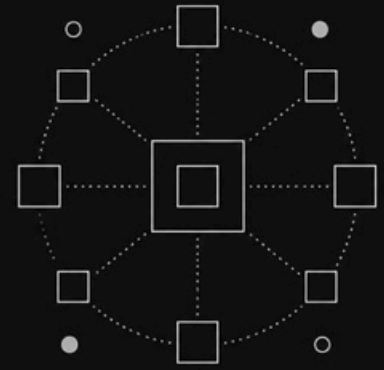
Before 2003

(IT as proprietary advantage,
unique edge, strategic
differentiator)



After 2003

(IT as commodity,
mandatory baseline,
competitive parity required)



INFRASTRUCTURE SHIFT

The "Cheap Revolution" and Cloud Foundation



The Dellification of IT

Expensive proprietary servers gave way to generic, modular, and cheap hardware —democratising access to computing power.



Cloud Infrastructure Arrives

High-speed data transmission and cloud platforms caught up with demand, making infrastructure elastic and scalable.



Invisible and Ubiquitous

IT became the plumbing of every modern organisation —quiet, reliable, and always-on.

Working Across Boundaries

1

Breaking Corporate Walls

Processes streamlined across suppliers, distributors, and customers in real time.

2

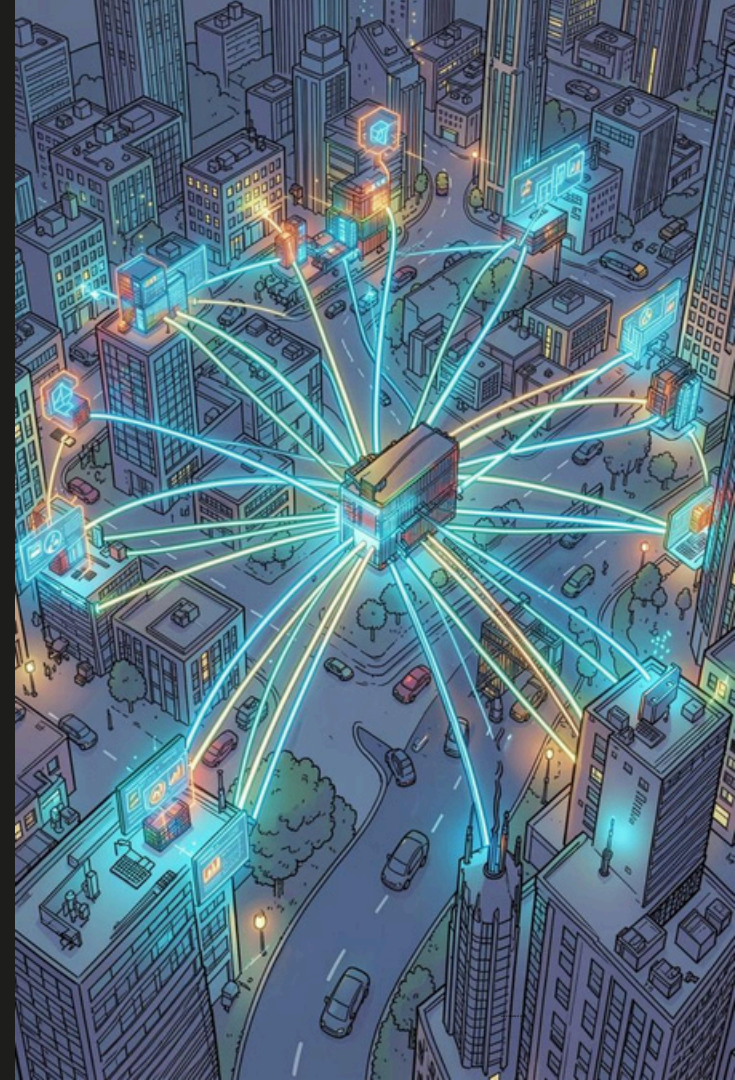
Demand-Pull World

Customer orders now trigger the creation of customised products on demand.

3

Virtual Enterprises

Tight digital ecosystems built with partners, banks, and even competitors.



India as a Global IT Hub

1991 Turning Point

Economic liberalisation and the STPI scheme provided vital satellite connectivity, opening India to global clients.

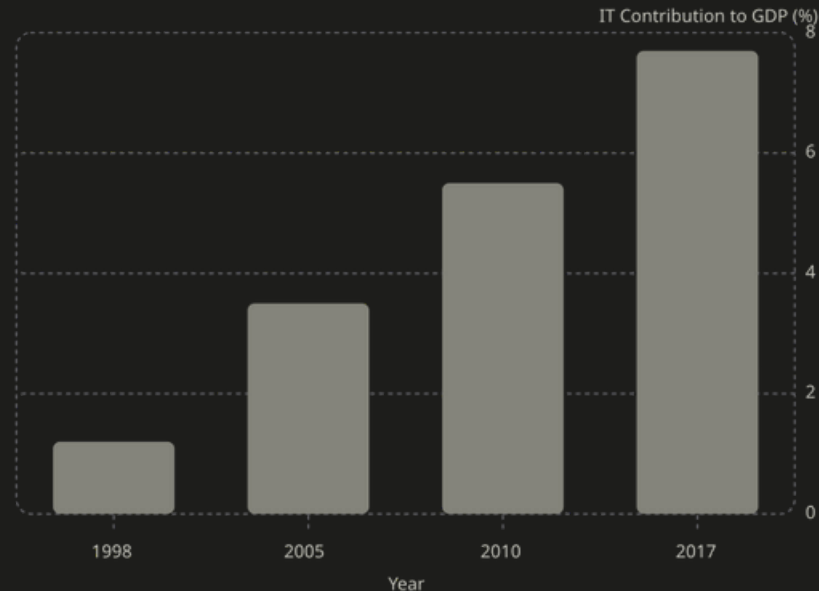
From Back-Office to Front-Line

India's industry evolved from basic software maintenance to high-value consulting, analytics, and product engineering.

The Economic Engine

IT sector contribution to Indian GDP surged from 1998 to 7.7% in 2017—a six-fold increase.

12% in



LOOKING AHEAD

Conclusion: The Future of Digital Business

Digital Convergence

Big Data, Analytics, and Social Media are no longer optional — they are the digital economy.

Strategic Re-Architecture

Companies must continuously re-architect around internet technologies to stay relevant and competitive.

Seamless Value Chains

The ultimate goal: technology so deeply integrated it becomes a natural, invisible part of life.

